THE PINK LEMON



Why Losing Isn't Always What It Looks Like

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CHAPTER ONE

Not One

I loved baseball before I had much language for winning or losing, and growing up in Cleveland in the 1990s made that pretty easy to do. The Indians had a loaded roster back then, with Kenny Lofton, Albert Belle and my favorite player, Omar Vizquel, who could make a ground ball up the middle look like something he'd planned the night before. We went to games at Jacobs Field, and a city that had waited a long time for a winner started believing, maybe a little too fast, that this might finally be the team.

The Indians made the World Series twice that decade and lost both times. I watched those games on TV at my grandma's house with my dad and my uncles. The first one, in 1995, was against the Atlanta Braves, which is a little funny to me now that I live in Atlanta. The second one, in 1997, hurt more. The Indians had the lead in the ninth inning of Game 7. Then the Florida Marlins tied it and won it in the eleventh. Nobody said much after that. I went quiet and got mad, then sat there and festered on it with a subtle animosity about the lost opportunity, which is pretty much how the men in my family handled losing.

As a kid I couldn't explain why being that close made it hurt worse than getting blown out. I just knew I wanted my team to win, and I knew I loved playing the game myself. I played pickup ball with my friends, spent time in batting cages and practiced whenever I could. When my dad took me to the library on the weekends, I'd grab

baseball books along with whatever else caught my eye. *Nolan Ryan's Pitcher's Bible* is the one I remember most. I liked the players, but what I really wanted to know was how people got good, why one guy could throw harder than everybody else, and what practice was actually changing when you did it every day.

My dad had a pretty simple answer for what you did when you weren't good enough yet, and the answer was that you kept going. That was how he handled most of life. If something didn't work, you didn't sit around feeling sorry for yourself for very long. You figured out what you needed to do and you tried again, because nobody was going to care enough about your situation to climb inside it and fix your life for you. I still believe that.

Some losses really are that simple. Sometimes you weren't ready, or somebody outworked you, or the other person had a skill you hadn't built yet. Sometimes you got distracted or let fear make the decision, or you figured wanting something badly would be enough. It happens to everybody. If I wasn't good enough or didn't prepare, I'd rather know that than have somebody protect my feelings with a story that isn't true, because talking about losing shouldn't let any of us off the hook for looking honestly at our own part.

Baseball taught me some of that, and it also taught me that the simple answer wasn't the whole answer. When I tried out for my high school team in eleventh grade, I felt ready, or at least the kind of ready I understood at the time. I'd played and practiced and learned the game the way I knew how. Then I got around the other kids who'd been getting ready for the same tryout, and I started noticing things I didn't know mattered.

Some of those kids had better equipment, and some had played a lot more organized baseball than I had. Some had travel teams and real coaching and the kind of practice that pickup games in the neigh-

borhood just can't give you. None of that meant they hadn't worked hard, because they had, and it didn't mean I'd done nothing, because I hadn't. We'd just come to the same tryout by different roads. It may have been the first time I understood how many people can want the same spot just as badly as you do. The roster only had so many places, and wanting one didn't make my preparation equal to everybody else's.

Business works the same way when a lot of companies are chasing the same customer. Wanting something can feel special when you're alone with it, and then you walk into a room full of people who want it just as much, and you realize wanting it is only where things start. After that, what matters is the preparation, who has access to what, and all the small details.

I made the team. I remember feeling relieved and proud when I found out, and I bring it up because for years I judged that whole season by how it ended. When the ending disappointed me, I treated the entire experience like a disappointment, including the part where I'd actually done what I set out to do.

Then I got hurt. It wasn't one big play. The injury was in my arm and shoulder, and it built up slowly over time in practice until I couldn't play the way I needed to. My dad didn't say much about it. I never really got to see what my full potential in baseball might have been, and that's the honest version of the story, so I don't need to make it bigger than it was. At the time, though, I was disappointed. Baseball had taken up a lot of room in my imagination, and losing it meant I had to find other things to imagine. Not long after that I took a job at a retail store, which was the first time I ever had my own money.

I grieved baseball for a while, and then I moved on. What I didn't understand yet was why this loss felt so different from the ones before

it. When another kid struck me out, there was something to learn from it. Maybe he had a better pitch than I'd seen before, or my timing was off, or I needed more practice against that kind of pitcher. The injury didn't give me anything like that. I'd spent most of my childhood learning that losing was information. You lose, so you get better. You lose, so you practice more. You lose, so you figure out what the winner did that you didn't. The injury ended my season without answering any of those questions, and I didn't have a place in my head to put a loss like that. I'd done enough to make the team, and I still didn't get the season I'd pictured, and for a long time I acted like the second part erased the first.

As I've gotten older I've noticed how fast people reach for an explanation once something is over. We say the winner worked harder and the loser didn't want it enough. We look at a company that made it and say they must have made better decisions, and we look at the one that failed and decide they must have made bad ones. We say the marriage that lasted was healthy and the one that ended was a mistake. Sometimes that's exactly right. A lot of the time it's more complicated than that, and we're reading the story backward from the ending and making up a reason that makes the ending feel like it was always going to happen.

We do the same thing with winners. After somebody succeeds, we go back through their life and start treating ordinary details like clues. Their morning routine, their mindset or a book on their shelf suddenly becomes the reason they won, even though nobody really knows how much any of it mattered. The coach they hired and the discipline they showed probably did matter. What we hardly ever do is look just as closely at the people who did a lot of the same things and still lost.

I didn't understand any of that in eleventh grade. I just knew baseball was turning into something I used to do. Other things moved forward and life kept moving. Years later, after I'd started teaching and coaching and building businesses and raising sons, and after I'd lost things that cost a lot more than a baseball season, I kept coming back to one question, which was what a loss actually proves.

Sometimes a loss proves a lot, and sometimes it proves almost nothing, and the difference matters because of what we usually do next. When people care about you, they want to make your pain useful as fast as they can. They tell you everything happens for a reason, or that God has something better, or that this is making you stronger, or to keep your head up. I understand why people say those things, because I've said every one of them myself.

I'm a Christian, and I believe God can use things I never would have chosen. I also don't think my faith asks me to pretend I understand why every painful thing happened. Those are two different claims. Some things in my life turned out to be useful later on, and some losses sent me somewhere I needed to go, and I can see that now because enough time has passed. That still doesn't mean every bad thing is fertilizer and we're supposed to keep digging until we find the flower. Sometimes we just don't know. Sometimes the only honest thing you can say is *I hate that this happened,* and I've gotten a lot more comfortable saying that.

What worries me more is what happens when we skip trying to understand a loss and go straight to fixing ourselves. If somebody beat you because they were better, then getting better makes sense. If the loss came down to something close to random, that calls for a different conversation. If something got taken from you, searching forever for your own personal failure can turn into punishment. If you've been winning at a game you don't even want to play anymore,

working harder might move you further from the life you actually want. And if you quietly stopped showing up for something you still wanted, that's a different conversation too. Those are different kinds of losses, and I didn't know that when I was seventeen.

What I knew back then was one thing, which was to get back up. I'm grateful my father taught me that, and the habit has carried me through some hard seasons. Learning when to keep moving, and where to point all that effort, took me a lot longer.

KEEP READING

That was one kind of loss. There are five.

The rest of *The Pink Lemon* sorts them out:

1. Somebody beat you
2. The margin was almost random
3. Something was taken
4. You were playing the wrong game
5. You walked out

Each one asks for a different response.

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